

» MATCH OF THE
FORTNIGHT

United in hope

Manchester United came back from **two goals down** to overcome an inspired Aston Villa.

MANCHESTER UNITED

3

Alejandro
Garnacho
59', 71'
Hojlund 82'

ASTON VILLA

2

McGinn 21'
Dendoncker 26'

Manchester United's stuttering season seemed to have reached its nadir when it slumped to a two-goal deficit inside 30 minutes to Aston Villa in a high-profile Boxing Day Premier League fixture at home.

As it stood, Unai Emery's Villa would have become an unlikely leader of the Premier League table, courtesy of goals from John McGinn and Leander Dendoncker — both goals stemmed from United's flat-footed defending from set pieces.

By the time the game cantered to the half-hour mark, United had clocked 400 goalless minutes across competitions, signalling a rot in performance that had put manager Erik ten Hag on the precipice of being unemployed going into the New Year.

But then, out of nowhere, the Red Devils remembered to be a top-level football team, again.

United's attacking unit, disjointed and dysfunctional for weeks, clicked in unison. Marcus Rashford, Rasmus Hojlund and Alejandro Garnacho — guided by the mercurial Bruno Fernandes — ravaged Villa's

defence, which had kept the offences of Manchester City and Arsenal at bay in previous matches.

However, a combination of inspired goalkeeping by Villa's Emiliano Martinez and tight offside calls ensured the visiting side retained its two-goal advantage at half-time.

Ten Hag's side continued in the same vein in the second half, stitching up coordinated attacks, targeting the high defensive line of Villa.

The pressure eventually bore fruit as Garnacho tapped in a grounded cross from Rashford in the left flank to put the home side back into the game.

The Argentinian winger soon levelled the score with a left-footed finish — which deflected off a Villa defender — from inside the box following a cross from the right wing.

United pressed on for a winner with vigour and found it following a melee in the penalty box after a corner was whipped in. Hojlund rifled in a volley to find the back of the net for the first time in his Premier League career to put the Red Devils ahead in the game finally.

This win could potentially reignite a flailing season for United, while Villa rued missing a glorious opportunity going into 2024 as the Premier League leader.

Last gasp: Manchester United's Rasmus Hojlund (centre) celebrates after scoring the winner for the Red Devils. AP

